


**ALBINDER SINGH
DHINDSA**

Group CEO,
Eternal

“Our current guidance (is) of 3,000 stores by March 2027... However, if the competition moderates in the near term, we would want to aim for 3,500-4,000 stores by March 2027”


**SRIHARSHA
MAJETY**

MD & Group CEO,
Swiggy

“Instamart’s recent investments into lower consumer-side monetisation have not yielded the desired incremental order growth amid irrational competition in the quick commerce space”

liver everything, whether light or heavy. There should be an increase in the per-order payout,” he says.

Quick commerce creates 62–64 jobs for every ₹1 crore monthly GMV, far more than modern trade (41–42 jobs) and e-commerce (25–29 jobs), according to a Kearney report from June 2025. While there are incentives for night gigs and weekend shifts, many gig workers say their earnings have halved in recent months.

Outside a Zepto dark store in Vaishali, a flight of stairs leads to a basement. Gig workers arrive on bicycles, low-speed electric two-wheelers and run-down motorcycles, exhaust pipes billowing smoke Satya Bahadur, a 42-year-old cycle rider, says he delivers 20–25 orders each day. He makes around ₹500–600 daily, and if he delivers 250 orders, there is a ₹7,000 incentive. “I was working in a factory making doors. For 12 hours of work, I made ₹12,000, and here I earn at least ₹15,000.”

There are many who say they are better off with gig work. Akash, 23, a Swiggy Instamart delivery partner in Ghaziabad, says his current job is better than a factory worker. “Earlier, I was working at an electronics factory in Noida. It is not easy to work on a production line. I was always under pressure. My monthly salary was merely ₹11,000. I used to get ₹8,500–9,000 in hand there. I could not save anything. As a gig worker, I earn ₹30,000 monthly,” he says.

Dark stores are making that fundamental shift in consumption. Naveen Malpani, Partner and Consumer and Retail Industry Leader at Grant Thornton Bharat, says they are changing the retail dynamics in India’s metros by compressing the supply chain to within a few kilometres of the consumer. “Over time, metros are witnessing a clear decoupling: essentials migrate to invisible fulfilment infrastructure, while malls and high streets evolve into discretionary, lifestyle-oriented destinations. This redefinition of urban retail catchments is unlikely to reverse,” he says.

UNDERCUTTING TRADITIONAL MODELS

Instead of the previous 10-minute delivery time, several apps now show less than 10 minutes, depending on how far the dark store is.

The story of quick commerce reshaping the retail landscape is not limited to any city. It’s happening across the country. In Bengaluru, at least 300 out of 1,000 supermarkets shut last year because of quick commerce companies, says PM Ganeshraam, chief founder patron, All India Consumer Products Distributors Federation (AICPDF). “Even first floor residents have stopped coming down to buy groceries.”

Ganeshraam explains that distributors are also shutting down because of predatory pricing and deep discounting practice adopted by quick commerce players. In order to retain their customers, mom-and-pop stores are trying to match the pricing with quick commerce. “Many of our players are selling at a loss without knowing what to do. We have suggested the government to bring MSP or minimum selling price. If they bring that, then q-commerce also cannot go below that price,” says Ganeshraam.

After conquering metros, quick commerce players are eyeing smaller cities like Madurai, Coimbatore, Nagpur, adds Ganeshraam.

For all its operational strain and earnings pressure, quick commerce is where India’s retail heavyweights believe the future is being decided. **BT**

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